

EP1 SEASON-NOTCH CANDIDATES, v1 (blind batch)

2026-09-01. Three sources (Fable, ChatGPT, Claude), merged, deduplicated, shuffled, authorship stripped per the blind-ranking rule. Skim; name the numbers that grab. Enthusiasm develops a candidate; silence re-runs the batch.

Two things to know while skimming, neither of which marks authorship:

1. **▲ SPINE** marks a line that contradicts a settled ruling (usually: it wires Brad into the season conspiracy or gives him an accomplice, when the spine's Brad acted alone and the arc rule keeps episode fingers off the season's head unless you explicitly connect them). Picking one of these is not a notch pick; it is a premise-level re-architecture of the season, decided as such.
2. **▲ care** marks a line that works but needs a small retcon or plants a deliberate misdirection; the note says which.

Convergence note: three sources independently generated "someone was at the dead man's file before us" (kept as three distinct variants: 5, 17, 31).

1. Gerald hears the finale twice, then asks, too casually, if anyone ever photographed the destroyed object. Told no, he looks relieved.
2. During booking, Brad gives an emergency contact: Thomas Quinn, Ally's father, dead for ten years. **▲ SPINE**
3. The killer's first question in custody is whether the real deckhand was ever found. Del says he seemed to genuinely not know.
4. Gerald studies Brad's arrest photograph and asks Ally who cropped the other man out. **▲ care:** booking photos are not cropped; works only as Gerald seeing something nobody else can.
5. Arthur Finch finds the deckhand's clipping was requested once before: the slip is dated a month before Ally's first episode aired.
6. Del plays Ally one unaired booking-room sentence: "Your father would have found me sooner." **▲ SPINE**
7. Mo hears the dead deckhand's name, stops polishing a glass and says, "That wasn't his name here."
8. The deckhand had no family, yet someone has paid for a small harbour memorial notice every year since he vanished.
9. The landlady says Brad never missed Ally's show, except the episode about her father's crash. **▲ care:** invents a past episode about the crash, and the source detail must reach Ally via Del to stay inside the anonymity ruling.
10. The killer spends his one phone call on a Havenbay number. It rings out. He doesn't ask to try again.
11. The Tip Line receives a woman saying, "You found the second man first," then she hangs up.
12. Del Cruz turns the forged identity papers over and says, "You don't buy work this good. Someone gives it to you." **▲ care:** the spine's papers were self-built with no accomplice, so this is Del being wrong on air; a knowing misdirection if kept.

13. Her source's congratulations arrive four minutes before Del Cruz calls her, and eleven before the arrest is announced anywhere.
14. Arthur finds Brad's false name pencilled beneath an old newsroom photograph of Ally's father. **▲ SPINE**
15. Playing the finale for Gerald, Ally watches him go still. Not at the killer's name. At the deckhand's.
16. The arresting officer asks Ally why Brad knew the address of the house where she grew up. **▲ SPINE**
17. When the deckhand's file is finally pulled, its request register shows one entry from years ago, blank where the name should be.
18. Gerald hears the 05:47 train time, turns off Ally's recorder and says, "Your father knew that train." **▲ SPINE**
19. The rookie signature closing the deckhand's file as "drifted, no action" is Del Cruz's own. She hands it over without a word about it. **▲ care:** needs a small Del retcon (she signed a low-risk file three years ago); heavy personal cost to a canon ally.
20. Brad asks for one phone call, then recites the private number Gerald disconnected after Ally's father died. **▲ SPINE**
21. The first tip after the finale is six words: "Ask your source who they lost."
22. Del opens Brad's wallet and finds a recent photograph of Ally entering the Rusty Anchor. **▲ SPINE:** Brad has been four hundred miles away; a recent photo means an agent in Havenbay, which is an accomplice.
23. Off the record, Del Cruz asks how her source knew details police never released. Ally realizes she never once wondered. **▲ care:** the source's letter was built from broadcast material; this implies otherwise, a deliberate misdirection if kept.
24. Her source's last message ends "mind how you go", a phrase Ally hasn't heard from anyone since she was sixteen.
25. Arthur finds the deckhand's name on a newspaper request slip dated the morning after Ally's father died. **▲ SPINE:** the deckhand vanished three years ago; no clipping about him existed ten years ago.
26. Through his lawyer, the killer sends Ally one line: "You were kinder about it than the last one."
27. A listener sends Ally a recording of Brad using her name six months before she began the podcast. **▲ SPINE**
28. Mo pours her celebration drink and says, not quite joking, "If your source ever comes in, their tab's still open."
29. The landlady recognizes Mo's voice from a call Brad took every Sunday; Mo says she never spoke to him. **▲ SPINE:** wires Mo into the new life; either an accomplice or a canon character lying.
30. Del receives another missing-person alert carrying Brad's photograph and a different name, filed ten years earlier. **▲ SPINE:** the exit was built once, starting two and a half years before Violet.
31. Arthur Finch asks Ally to return a clipping she never borrowed. The old request slip shows her surname in handwriting she doesn't recognize.
32. Gerald reads Brad's arrest inventory, taps one ordinary car key and says, "That belongs to me." **▲ SPINE**
33. The deckhand's stored belongings go to a next of kin nobody knew existed. The claim was filed the day after the arrest.
34. A photograph of Ally interviewing Ruby arrives the morning after the arrest, taken from inside Ruby's house.

35. When the arrest hits the news, Mo nods once and quietly takes down a photograph from behind the bar before Ally arrives.
36. Del says Brad asked one question after arrest: "Does Gerald still keep the spare room locked?" **▲ SPINE**
37. A week later, her source sends one photograph: the destroyed object, whole, on somebody's kitchen table, taken years before Ally found the scene. **▲ care:** does not un-destroy the object but resurrects its evidentiary life; changes what Ep2 inherits.
38. At arraignment the killer answers only to the dead man's name, correcting the judge gently, like a habit he intends to keep.
39. Arthur watches the booking footage twice and asks, "Why is he wearing your father's watch?" **▲ SPINE**
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OUTCOME (2026-09-01, Stephen)

No batch line adopted. Stephen's verdict on the class: every candidate is a reaction; the notch needed an action. His own design, sharpened in-session, is RULED as F1 (structure v2.2): the deckhand's photographs, kept by the skipper in case anyone came asking, opened at the accounting; Gerald goes still at one, asks for it and for silence, a few things to check first. Cost: what Ally described, she erased.

Stephen's per-line scores, kept as reader data (line: score): 1:5 2:7 3:3 4:5 5:3 6:7 7:6 8:3 9:3 10:5 11:6 12:3 13:2 14:7 15:6 16:7 17:3 18:2 19:3 20:3 21:3 22:3 23:3 24:5 25:3 26:4 27:3 28:4 29:3 30:5 31:5 32:6 33:5 34:4 35:7 36:6 37:7 38:5 39:3.

Pattern in the 7s: every 7 except 35 and 37 is Thomas-linked, and all Thomas-linked 7s carry the SPINE flag: his taste pulls hard toward the father thread, harder than the Ep1 rulings can spend. Season planning should treat that as the demand signal it is. **Salvage bank (unspent, nothing approved):** 35 (Mo takes down a photograph), 37 (the destroyed object photographed whole, years before), 2/6/14/16 (the Brad-to-Quinn class, usable only as a future season re-architecture), 15 (going still at the name: absorbed into the ruled notch), 8 (the paid memorial notice), 33 (the next of kin who never existed).